

THE MYSTERIOUS STRANGER

Written by
Christian O. Reyes

Based on
"No. 44, The Mysterious Stranger"
and
"The Chronicle of Young Satan"

by Mark Twain

FADE IN:

EXT. ST. PETERSBURG - 1702 - DAWN

A village caught between centuries. Cobblestone streets. A church dominating the high end of the market square. A river to the east. Gas lamps burning low in the early morning. The bell in the church tower strikes six.

INT. ANTIQUE SHOP - BACK ROOM - BEFORE DAWN

A blank page. A quill moving across it. Ink drying on words already written.

THEODOR, old now, sits at his father's worktable. He is writing by lamplight.

THEODOR (V.O.)

It was in seventeen-hundred
and two, in the village of
St. Petersburg, that I first
saw him. I did not know then
what he was. I know now that
I still do not fully know.
But I am writing it down
while it is still clear,
because I think it matters
that someone did.

THEODOR (V.O.)

His name was Philip Traum.

EXT. ST. PETERSBURG - MARKET STREET - MORNING

THEODOR, 16, sweeps the step outside his father's antique shop. Ink-stained hands. The face of a boy who reads too much and sleeps too little.

NIKOLAUS, 16, comes down the street eating bread.

NIKOLAUS

You were up late.

THEODOR

Reading.

NIKOLAUS

What.

THEODOR

Aurelius. A Roman emperor who wrote about the indifference of the universe.

NIKOLAUS

Does it have a story in it. People. Someone who wants something.

THEODOR

Not exactly.

NIKOLAUS

Then it is a punishment.
He takes the broom and props it against the wall.

NIKOLAUS (CONT'D)

Seppi is at the mill gate.

EXT. ST. PETERSBURG - MARKET SQUARE - MORNING

The market square coming alive. Bread sellers. A blacksmith already working. Children crossing to school.

Theodor passes the house of FATHER ADOLF, the senior priest whose reputation rests on having personally met the Devil and thrown a bottle at him. Father Adolf is not afraid of the Devil. This is why everyone is afraid of Father Adolf.

He passes the smaller house of FATHER PETER, the suspended priest. Through the open window, MARGET, 18, Father Peter's niece, practices harp scales. She has been teaching herself to play better since her students stopped coming. There is nothing else to do while the house is mortgaged and her uncle sits under accusation and the village pretends she does not exist.

At the far end of the square, the ASTROLOGER moves through the morning crowd in his tall pointed hat and long robe printed with stars, carrying his big book. People step aside. Father Adolf steps aside. Even the Bishop listens

to the Astrologer.

Father Peter does not step aside for him. Father Peter has called him a fraud and a charlatan to his face in this square. This is why Father Peter no longer has a parish. This is why Marget no longer has students. This is why the house will be taken from them by morning if nothing changes.

EXT. ST. PETERSBURG - MILL ROAD - MORNING

Theodor and Nikolaus find SEPPI, 15, waiting at the gate post.

SEPPI

There was a cart outside
Father Peter's house this
morning. Solomon Isaacs. The
mortgage is due tomorrow.

NIKOLAUS

Will he lose the house.

THEODOR

Unless something changes
before morning.

SEPPI

Father Peter says God will
provide.

NIKOLAUS

Father Peter says a lot of
things that have not helped
him recently.

SEPPI

He is a good man.

NIKOLAUS

I know he is. Being good has
not protected him from any of
this.

EXT. RIVER ROAD - MORNING

The river runs fast with spring melt. The three boys walk the bank road.

At the east bend, LISA BRANDT, 6, sits on a flat rock at the water's edge. One leg holds differently than the other. She has a stick and is dragging it through the current, watching what the water does around the resistance.

NIKOLAUS
calling out
Lisa. Come away from the
edge.

Lisa looks up, waves with the stick, and turns back to the river.

NIKOLAUS (CONT'D)
She never listens.

THEODOR
Her mother is managing a debt
and a dead husband. She
cannot watch the river every
hour.

They stand watching Lisa measure the current.

EXT. ST. PETERSBURG - MARKET SQUARE - MORNING

The witch commission has been active in the region for two years. Every week brings new arrests from neighboring parishes. The village watches this the way people watch a fire moving across a field toward them.

Theodor crosses the square. A WOMAN is being questioned by two of Father Adolf's men outside the church door. She is fifty years old and has been seen talking to a cat.

People watch from a distance. No one intervenes.

SEPPI
She is not a witch.
appearing beside
Theodor

THEODOR
I know.

SEPPI

Then why is no one saying
anything.
Because saying something
marks you.

EXT. ST. PETERSBURG - HILLSIDE ABOVE TOWN - AFTERNOON

The three boys lie in the grass at the top of their hill.
The town below. The river to the east.

Nikolaus has a pipe. No fire.

NIKOLAUS

I left the flint at home.

SEPPI

You always leave it at home.

NIKOLAUS

I always mean to bring it.
A stranger comes through the trees and sits down with
them. Young. Well-dressed.

PHILIP

Fire? That is easy.
He had not been spoken to. Nikolaus had not said anything
aloud. Philip takes the pipe, breathes on it, the tobacco
burns ash and red amber.

The boys are on their feet and running. They get ten yards
and stop.

PHILIP (CONT'D)

I will not harm you. I only
want company.
They stand at the tree line. They want to run and they
want to stay.

They stay.

PHILIP (CONT'D)

Look in your pockets.
They look. Oranges. Apples. Grapes. Better than any fruit
they have tasted.

NIKOLAUS

How.

PHILIP

It comes natural. Like other things.

NIKOLAUS

What other things.

PHILIP

I will show you.

They come back. Philip takes clay from the earth and shapes a squirrel that scrambles up the nearest tree and sits on a branch barking at them. A dog the size of a mouse that chases it. Birds that fly off singing when he opens his hand.

The boys inch closer with each one.

Then Philip begins something much larger. Five hundred miniature figures swarming in the grass between them, building. A castle taking shape course by course. Tiny women carry mortar on their heads. Tiny men lay stone. The detail extraordinary, down to the expressions on faces no bigger than a grain of wheat.

SEPPI

They are real.

SEPPI

Can they see us.

PHILIP

Yes. You are their sky.

NIKOLAUS

What do they think we are.

PHILIP

Gods. Or weather. Depending on how far their theology has developed.

PHILIP (CONT'D)

Seppi, make cannon for the walls. Nikolaus, halberdiers

with breastplates and
helmets. Theodor, cavalry
with horses.

They work. Their figures are terrible. The cavalry horses
have legs of uneven length. The cannon are bent. Philip
examines Nikolaus's work.

PHILIP (CONT'D)

These are the worst I have
seen.

He touches them. The cavalry comes alive and immediately
reels because of the legs, stumbling into each other,
falling down. The cannon fire a salute and burst, killing
their crews. The boys laugh in spite of themselves.

In one corner of the castle yard two tiny workers begin to
argue. Their voices a sound like bees. They lock together.
Philip reaches out and crushes them between his fingers,
wipes his hand on his sleeve, and goes on talking.

The boys go still.

THEODOR

You killed them.

PHILIP

They ceased.

THEODOR

That is the same thing.

PHILIP

No. It is not. If it were I
would have felt something.

SEPPI

They had wives. I saw them.

PHILIP

Yes. They did.

He goes on building.

NIKOLAUS

What are you.

PHILIP

An angel. The nephew of
Satan. He is my uncle. Before
the fall he was blameless. We
others cannot sin. We do not
know what it is. It is a good
family.

NIKOLAUS

Satan.

PHILIP

Yes. In public I use a
different name. Philip Traum.

SEPPI

Traum.

He finishes the castle. Every detail. Flags on the
turrets. Artillery in position.

Then he conjures a black cloud above it. Lightning. The
ground trembles. The tiny people stream out through the
gates.

Philip brushes them back inside.

NIKOLAUS

Let them out.

Philip does not. The magazine explodes. The castle
collapses into a crack in the earth that closes over
everything.

Five hundred people. Gone.

The boys look at where the castle was.

PHILIP

They were of no value.

NIKOLAUS

It was murder.

PHILIP

Brutes do not act cruelly.
Cruelty is a human capacity
alone. I have no moral sense.
I cannot do wrong because I
do not know what wrong is.

THEODOR
Then what was that.

PHILIP
What it looks like from
outside when something acts
without the moral sense. You
find it monstrous. I find it
unremarkable. That is the
whole difference between us.

PHILIP (CONT'D)
Do not tell anyone about me.
You will try but the words
will not come.

NIKOLAUS
Will you come back.
He dissolves. The shape of him remains visible for a
moment longer than physics allows, colors moving through
it the way colors move through a soap bubble just before
it vanishes. Then nothing. The air where he stood is
simply air.

The three boys sit in the grass. The depression in the
earth where the castle was the only evidence.

NIKOLAUS
I suppose none of it
happened.

THEODOR
It happened.

EXT. ST. PETERSBURG - HILLSIDE - LATER THAT AFTERNOON

SEPPI
He knew our names. Before we
said them.

NIKOLAUS
He knew what I was going to
say before I said it.

THEODOR

He said he knows what will
happen to everyone in this
town.

NIKOLAUS
Does that include us.

THEODOR
I did not ask.

SEPPI
I do not want to know.

NIKOLAUS
I do.

SEPPI
To see everything and feel
none of it. That sounds
lonely.

NIKOLAUS
He is an angel. Angels do not
get lonely.

SEPPI
How do you know.

EXT. ST. PETERSBURG - MARKET SQUARE - FOLLOWING MORNING

The village is talking. Father Peter was on the hillside
yesterday and found a wallet in the path. Stuffed with
gold. Eleven hundred ducats. He paid Solomon Isaacs. The
mortgage is cleared.

Father Peter says it is the plain hand of Providence.
Others say it looks more like the hand of Satan.

The boys know where it came from. They open their mouths
and find the words will not come.

INT. FATHER PETER'S HOUSE - PARLOR - MORNING

More food on the table than the house has had in months.
URSULA, 60s, the housekeeper, moves through the room.
WILHELM MEIDLING, 24, sits near the window. He has been

here through the entire year when everyone else stopped coming.

Marget is at the harp. She plays a full chord. The first time in months she has played without watching the door.

MARGET

I do not understand where it came from.

NIKOLAUS

It is yours. Every coin.

MARGET

Someone left it there.
Someone had to.

NIKOLAUS

Not a human being.

Marget looks from Nikolaus to Theodor. Neither elaborates.

MARGET

Father Peter will not ask where it came from, will he.

THEODOR

No.

MARGET

Then I will not either.

She plays another chord. Wilhelm watches her from across the room.

WILHELM

to the boys
Whatever it was, I am glad of it.

EXT. ST. PETERSBURG - MARKET SQUARE - DAYS LATER

The Astrologer has thought carefully about Father Peter's money. He goes to Father Adolf. Father Adolf goes to the Bishop. By afternoon, Father Peter is under arrest.

The charge was that he stole eleven hundred ducats from the Astrologer's desk. The amounts match exactly. Father

Peter was alone in his house on the day the money disappeared. Seven witnesses.

The boys know it is a lie. They cannot say how they know.

**EXT. ST. PETERSBURG - OUTSIDE FATHER PETER'S HOUSE -
EVENING**

The gate. Marget. Wilhelm is there.

MARGET
Go home. Being seen here will
ruin you.

WILHELM
Let it.

MARGET
You have a practice to build.
You cannot afford this.

WILHELM
I know him. He did not steal
anything.

MARGET
Everyone in this village
knows he did not steal
anything.

WILHELM
Then I will say so in court.

MARGET
Wilhelm.

WILHELM
I am not going.
She goes inside. He stays.

INT. ANTIQUE SHOP - BACK ROOM - EVENING

Theodor's father at the table, letter in hand. He sets it
down when Theodor comes in.

THEODOR'S FATHER

You were in the square this morning.

THEODOR'S FATHER
Frau Engel.

THEODOR
They took her in.

THEODOR'S FATHER
I know. Her husband came by
this afternoon.
He sets the letter down.

THEODOR'S FATHER (CONT'D)
I want you to stay away from
Father Peter's house.

THEODOR
Why.

THEODOR'S FATHER
Because the Astrologer is
watching it. Because Father
Adolf is watching it. Because
you are sixteen years old and
this town eats its own and I
would like you to survive it.

THEODOR
Father Peter did not steal
anything.

THEODOR'S FATHER
I know that.

THEODOR
Then.

THEODOR'S FATHER
Then nothing. Knowing a thing
and being able to say it are
different things in this town
right now. Stay away from the
house.
Theodor looks at his father.

THEODOR
Nikolaus goes there.

THEODOR'S FATHER
Nikolaus's father does not
know.

THEODOR
You are asking me to leave
Marget alone.

THEODOR'S FATHER
I am asking you to stay
alive.

THEODOR
All right.
He goes to his room. His father sits alone with the
letter.

INT. FATHER PETER'S HOUSE - KITCHEN - EVENING

Philip is at the table when the boys arrive, sitting there
as though he has always eaten here. Agnes the cat is at
his feet.

MARGET
to Philip
Do you know my uncle.

PHILIP
I know of him.

MARGET
He did not steal anything.

PHILIP
No. He did not.

MARGET
Will he go free.

PHILIP
Yes.

MARGET

How can you know that.

PHILIP

I know a great many things.

Ursula watches Philip from across the kitchen with deep suspicion.

PHILIP (CONT'D)

to Ursula

Check your pocket.

Ursula checks. Four silver groschen.

URSULA

Where did those come from.

PHILIP

The cat. Four groschen every morning. She is a Lucky Cat.

URSULA

That is nonsense.

PHILIP

Check again tomorrow.

Agnes blinks at Ursula.

EXT. ST. PETERSBURG - ROAD OUTSIDE TOWN - DAYS LATER

Theodor and Philip walk at the edge of town where the path thins out and the houses fall behind.

THEODOR

You know what will happen to everyone in this town.

THEODOR

Lisa Brandt.

PHILIP

In eleven days she will be at the river. The bank at the east bend gives way. She goes into the current. Nikolaus will be on the road above. He will hear her. He will go in after her.

Theodor stops.

PHILIP (CONT'D)
They both drown.

THEODOR
Change it.

PHILIP
I cannot change it without
changing every life that
follows. Some of those
futures are worse. Most of
them are worse.

THEODOR
Then I will change it. I will
keep Nikolaus away from the
river.

PHILIP
On that day Nikolaus will
open his window in the night
and fall back asleep twelve
minutes late. Those twelve
minutes put him at the east
bend exactly when Lisa goes
in. If you remove him from
the road entirely she falls
with no one nearby.

THEODOR
The twelve minutes are
everything.

PHILIP
Yes.

THEODOR
What happens to Lisa's body
afterward.

PHILIP
Her mother cannot pay the
debt to the carpenter. The
debt transfers to the only

remaining asset. The
carpenter holds papers. Four
days.

THEODOR

You know all of this and say
nothing until I ask word by
word.

PHILIP

If I spoke every time someone
in this town was about to
suffer I would never stop.

THEODOR

That is not an answer.

PHILIP

No. It is not.

PHILIP (CONT'D)

There is something else. I
changed Nikolaus's life the
night he opened that window.
If I had left the chain as it
was, he would have arrived
four minutes earlier and
saved Lisa. He would have
caught cold from the water. A
scarlet fever would follow.
Forty-six years in a bed.
Deaf, dumb, blind. Praying
every day for death. I chose
the drowning.

PHILIP

Yes.

THEODOR

You chose it for him.

THEODOR

And Lisa. You chose the river
for her too.

PHILIP

From ten years of pain after
an accident and then nineteen
years I will not describe to
you. Yes. I chose the river.

THEODOR
His mother will not know any
of that.

PHILIP
No.

THEODOR
She will just have a dead
son.
Theodor walks on.

INT. ANTIQUE SHOP - NIGHT

Theodor at the worktable. His father already asleep
upstairs.

He has been sitting here since he got home. He has not lit
a lamp. He sits in the dark.

Philip appears in the back and sits in his chair.

THEODOR
He does not know.

PHILIP
No.

THEODOR
Nikolaus. He does not know
what is coming for him.

PHILIP
No.

THEODOR
He was talking about building
a boat. He was talking about
it at supper. Asking his
father for the wood. He has
eleven days left to live and

he was talking about building
a boat.

THEODOR
Should I tell him.

PHILIP
Would it help him.

THEODOR
I do not know. It would help
me. To not be carrying it
alone.

PHILIP
That is a different question.

THEODOR
Will he suffer. When it
happens.

PHILIP
No. The river is fast. It is
over quickly.

THEODOR
And Lisa.

PHILIP
The same.

THEODOR
Tell Seppi.

PHILIP
You may tell Seppi. I told
you that.

THEODOR
Seppi said seeing everything
and feeling none of it sounds
lonely.

PHILIP
Yes. He said that.

THEODOR

What did you think.

PHILIP

I have been thinking about it
since.

EXT. ST. PETERSBURG - RIVER BANK - MORNING

Theodor finds Seppi by the river early, before Nikolaus is
awake.

He tells him.

Seppi's face goes white. He does not speak for a long
time. They stand by the water.

SEPPI

Eleven days.

SEPPI

Does he know.

THEODOR

No.

SEPPI

We cannot tell him.

THEODOR

No.

SEPPI

So we just watch. For eleven
days we just watch and know
and he does not know.

Seppi looks at the river.

SEPPI

We should be with him. Every
day. We should use every day.

SEPPI

Without him knowing why.

They stand there. The river going past. Eleven days of it
left to count.

INT. ANTIQUE SHOP - BACK ROOM - NIGHT

Theodor cannot sleep. He sits at the worktable with the lamp and writes in his notebook. Not about Philip. About Nikolaus.

What he remembers. Things from years back. The time Nikolaus gave him half his lunch every day for a week when Theodor lost his and did not say a word about it. The time they were nine and Nikolaus took a punishment at school for something Theodor did. The time last spring when Nikolaus said without any preamble that he was glad they were friends and then changed the subject before Theodor had to answer.

He writes it all down.

EXT. ST. PETERSBURG - RIVER BANK - MORNING

Theodor and Seppi. They have told each other they are coming to the river to fish. They are not fishing. They are sitting on the bank watching the water.

SEPPI

He asked me yesterday why we keep giving him things.

THEODOR

What did you say.

SEPPI

I said I had been meaning to for a long time and kept forgetting.

THEODOR

Did he believe you.

SEPPI

I think so. He was pleased.
The river goes past.

SEPPI (CONT'D)

Six days.

SEPPI

Do you think Philip is
watching.

THEODOR
Philip watches everything.

SEPPI
Does that bother you.

SEPPI
Me too.

SEPPI (CONT'D)
Theodor. Do you believe in
God.

SEPPI
Even after everything Philip
has shown you.

THEODOR
I believe God exists. I am
less certain about His
character.

SEPPI
I pray every night. For my
mother. For Nikolaus. I have
been praying for Nikolaus
every night for five days.

THEODOR
I know.

SEPPI
Do you think it does
anything.

THEODOR
I do not know. Philip would
say no. But Philip cannot
feel anything and I think
feeling something might be
part of how it works.

SEPPI
That is not very certain.

THEODOR

No. It is not.

Seppi picks up a stone and throws it into the river.

SEPPI

I am going to keep praying
anyway.

THEODOR

Yes. Keep praying.

EXT. ST. PETERSBURG - VARIOUS - DAYS SIX THROUGH TEN

They are with Nikolaus every hour they can find. School.
The cooper's yard. The road to the river. The hill.

Nikolaus notices they are always there and is pleased by
it and says so and they let him be pleased.

He talks about the dance he is planning. He has asked
Lotte Engel if she will come and she said yes. He talks
about this with great happiness. Theodor and Seppi listen.

On day eight Nikolaus says that he has never felt so
valued by his friends as he has this week and he does not
know what he has done to deserve it.

Seppi has to look away.

On day nine Nikolaus says that after the dance he wants to
start building the boat. He has the design worked out. He
wants Theodor to help with the carving.

Theodor says yes.

EXT. ST. PETERSBURG - HILLSIDE - EVENING

The last evening. Theodor and Seppi on their hill.
Nikolaus has gone home.

SEPPI

Tomorrow.

SEPPI

I keep thinking there must be
something we can do.

THEODOR
I know.

SEPPI
Philip says there is not.

THEODOR
Philip says every version of
changing it makes things
worse.

SEPPI
Do you believe him.

THEODOR
I have been asking myself
that every day.

SEPPI
And.

THEODOR
I believe he sees what he
says he sees. I believe the
forty-six years were real. I
believe the chain is real. I
do not accept it. But I
believe it.

SEPPI
Accepting and believing are
different things.
The last light over the town. The last ordinary evening.

SEPPI
He said he had never had such
a good week.

SEPPI (CONT'D)
That is something.

THEODOR
Yes. It is something.

EXT. ST. PETERSBURG - RIVER ROAD - ELEVEN DAYS LATER - DAY

Theodor has been on the road since morning. He watches the east bend from upstream. Lisa is on her rock with her stick. He has turned over every approach. Philip has explained what follows each one.

He stays where he is.

In the afternoon a cart horse upstream breaks through the soft bank and goes into the river. The driver shouts. People come from the road.

Theodor turns toward the noise.

When he turns back, Lisa is not on the rock.

He runs.

EXT. RIVER - EAST BEND - CONTINUOUS

The water below the rock is dark and fast. He shouts her name. No answer.

Nikolaus arrives from the road above at a dead run. He does not stop at the bank. He goes off it straight into the current.

Theodor goes in after him. The current is fast and cold. He fights toward Nikolaus, gets a hand on his collar, and the current takes them both. Theodor catches a root on the bank and holds on. Nikolaus goes under.

Theodor pulls himself out of the water. He is alone on the bank.

Across the river, Philip stands in the shallows downstream. He has been there the whole time. He watched all of it.

They find Nikolaus downstream at the mill wheel. They find Lisa further down.

People come from the village. Someone goes for the mothers.

Theodor stands on the bank and watches them carry Nikolaus out of the water.

INT. NIKOLAUS'S HOUSE - MORNING - NEXT DAY

Nikolaus's mother moves through the house doing small useless things. Straightening. Folding. Keeping her hands occupied.

Theodor stands in the doorway.

NIKOLAUS'S MOTHER

I sent him out.

NIKOLAUS'S MOTHER (CONT'D)

His father whipped him the night before. He was out with you boys too late and I did not save him from it. I was angry. And then in the morning I sent him out to look for the Brandt girl.

THEODOR

It was not because of the whipping. It was not because you sent him.

NIKOLAUS'S MOTHER

He was talking about you two the night before. How much he cared about you. That was what he was thinking while I sat here being angry with him.

She folds the same cloth she has already folded.

Theodor has nothing to give her. He goes.

INT. NIKOLAUS'S HOUSE - PARLOR - THE AFTERNOON AFTER

Theodor is sitting in the parlor. He does not know how long he has been here. Nikolaus's father came in once and looked at him and went back out.

Nikolaus's mother comes in with water and puts it on the table and sits across from Theodor.

NIKOLAUS'S MOTHER

He was happy this week.

NIKOLAUS'S MOTHER
I do not know what you boys
were up to but he was happier
this week than I have seen
him in a year.

THEODOR
He was talking about a boat
he wanted to build.

NIKOLAUS'S MOTHER
I know. He showed me the
design.

NIKOLAUS'S MOTHER (CONT'D)
I sent him out.

THEODOR
He would have gone anyway. He
heard her.

NIKOLAUS'S MOTHER
He always goes when someone
needs help. He never stops to
think about himself first.
She smooths her hands on her apron.

NIKOLAUS'S MOTHER (CONT'D)
That is who he was.

THEODOR
Yes. That is who he was.

EXT. ST. PETERSBURG - BRANDT HOUSE - THREE DAYS LATER

Frau Brandt sits outside in the dirt. She has been there
since the men came. She rocks slightly. From inside the
house, the sound of furniture being moved. The carpenter's
men.

SEPPI
to Theodor
Father Peter went to the
Bishop. The Bishop said the
papers were legal.
Frau Brandt speaks to the sky.

FRAU BRANDT

There is no God. There is no
God. If there were a God he
would not let this happen. He
would have stopped it. But he
did not stop it. There is no
God.

Her voice carries down the empty street.

**EXT. ST. PETERSBURG - ROAD OUTSIDE TOWN - NIGHT AFTER THE
DROWNING**

Theodor finds Philip at the edge of town where they
usually walk. He has been looking for him since he left
Nikolaus's house.

THEODOR

You told me you chose the
drowning over the forty-six
years.

THEODOR

You chose it for Nikolaus.

THEODOR

Did you choose it for him or
did you choose it because it
was tidier.

Philip stops walking.

PHILIP

What do you mean.

THEODOR

I mean did you look at two
futures and choose the one
that was better for Nikolaus
or did you choose the one
that was better for the
chain.

PHILIP

Those are the same thing.

THEODOR

Are they.

PHILIP

The chain is made of lives.
Choosing what is better for
the chain is choosing what is
better for the people in it.

THEODOR

Nikolaus did not get to
choose.

PHILIP

No. He did not.

THEODOR

His mother did not get to
choose.

PHILIP

No.

THEODOR

Lisa did not get to choose.

PHILIP

No.

THEODOR

Then who did it serve. The
choice.

PHILIP

Nikolaus. It served Nikolaus.

THEODOR

He is dead.

PHILIP

He is not in a bed for
forty-six years unable to
move or speak or see.

THEODOR

He would have preferred to
make that choice himself.

PHILIP

Would he. At sixteen, knowing what was coming?

THEODOR

Yes. I think he would have. I think he would have chosen the river and known why.

PHILIP

Perhaps.

THEODOR

Not perhaps. I knew him.

PHILIP

Yes. You did.

They stand on the road.

PHILIP (CONT'D)

I did not ask him because I could not ask him. I am not capable of that kind of conversation with a human being. What I did was see two futures and choose the one that looked better from where I stand.

THEODOR

That is honest.

PHILIP

Yes. It is not enough. I know that.

THEODOR

It is also not enough.

PHILIP

No. It is not.

INT. ANTIQUE SHOP - THAT NIGHT

Theodor comes in late. His father at the counter.

THEODOR'S FATHER

You were at the river today.

THEODOR'S FATHER
You could not have saved
them.

THEODOR
I know.

THEODOR'S FATHER
Then stop carrying it as
though you could have.

THEODOR
Is that how it works.

THEODOR'S FATHER
No. It is not. But it is what
I have.

He goes upstairs.

Philip comes in through the back and takes his chair.

THEODOR
You stood on the bank and
watched.

THEODOR
Both of them.

THEODOR
She was six years old and he
was sixteen.

THEODOR
Give me one true thing about
her. Not the chain. Just her.

PHILIP
She had a map of the river
from her bank to the mill
wheel more accurate than the
surveyor's chart in your
father's shop. She made it by
watching the current for two
years. She was planning to
draw it on paper when she

found paper she considered adequate.

THEODOR
And Nikolaus.

PHILIP
He was kind in ways that would have cost him everything eventually. He drowned in a river at sixteen. That is a better death than forty-six years in a bed praying for death.

THEODOR
His mother does not know that.

PHILIP
No.

THEODOR
She thinks she let him get whipped the night before he died and she is going to carry that every day she has left.

PHILIP
Yes. She is.

THEODOR
You are fine with that.

PHILIP
I am not fine or not fine with it. I can see what each version looks like. She cannot. That is the only difference between us on this question.

THEODOR
Go away.

He goes.

INT. ANTIQUE SHOP - DAYS LATER

Theodor and Seppi at the worktable. Late.

SEPPI

My mother is worse.

THEODOR

I did not know.

SEPPI

She does not want people to know. She says it makes her feel like furniture someone is deciding what to do with.

He turns his cup around in his hands.

SEPPI (CONT'D)

Does he know what happens to her.

THEODOR

I asked him.

SEPPI

And.

THEODOR

She recovers.

SEPPI

He said that.

SEPPI

Do you believe him.

THEODOR

He does not lie. He says things that are terrible and he says them plainly and they turn out to be true. I believe him.

SEPPI

All right.

EXT. ST. PETERSBURG - TOWN SQUARE - FIVE DAYS LATER

A crowd before the church steps. The Bishop reads from a scroll. Frau Brandt stands before him.

BISHOP

Frau Margarethe Brandt,
having publicly denounced
Almighty God and given
evidence of congress with
diabolical forces, it is the
finding of this office that
you are excommunicated from
the sacraments and the
community of the faithful.

FRAU BRANDT

My daughter is dead.

BISHOP

Separated from the joys of
heaven and delivered to the
secular arm.

FRAU BRANDT

She was six years old and a
man took her body for a debt
and you are holding court.

The church bells begin. The Bishop raises his voice.

Theodor at the back of the crowd. Philip beside him.

THEODOR

Do something.

PHILIP

No.

THEODOR

She has done nothing wrong.

PHILIP

No. She has not.

THEODOR

Then help her.

PHILIP

This town has done this to
women for a century. Stopping
this ceremony does not change
the town that produces it.

Several men push toward Frau Brandt. Philip breathes once
in their direction. They drop, each clutching a rib.

THEODOR

What did you do.

PHILIP

Broke a rib apiece. Their
lives are changed by those
minutes of pain. Some of
those lives are better for
it.

THEODOR

Some.

PHILIP

Not all.

The Bishop finishes. Frau Brandt stands in the square with
her sentence given.

EXT. ST. PETERSBURG - TOWN SQUARE - THE BURNING

The stake. The crowd. Frau Brandt chained and calm. The
torch waiting.

She looks out at the faces watching her.

FRAU BRANDT

We played together once, in
long-ago days when we were
innocent little creatures.
For the sake of that, I
forgive you.

The torch touches the wood.

Theodor watches and does not look away.

Philip stands beside him. When it is over Theodor walks
through the dispersing crowd and out of the square.

INT. ANTIQUE SHOP - THAT NIGHT

Philip in his chair.

THEODOR

She is in heaven now.

PHILIP

Before the smoke reached the spire.

THEODOR

She would rather have Lisa.

PHILIP

Yes. That is the one true thing about today.

THEODOR

The moral sense.

THEODOR

You say it is what makes cruelty possible. But Frau Brandt standing in that square and forgiving them. That is also the moral sense.

PHILIP

Yes. It is both things. The capacity to imagine another person's suffering used to destroy them. And the capacity to imagine it and forgive anyway. The same instrument.

THEODOR

Then it is not only the problem.

PHILIP

I did not say it was only the problem. I said it was the mechanism. What it produces depends on the person holding it.

THEODOR

That is the first thing you
have said that sounds like it
might mean something.

PHILIP

It is accurate. Whether it
means something is your
problem.

A woman is being led through the square. She is not Frau
Brandt. She is one of the school teachers, young, someone
whose only offense is that three girls in her class were
found with marks on their skin that the commission decided
were the devil's.

The crowd watches. Theodor and Seppi are in it.

The teacher walks with her head up. She does not look at
the faces.

SEPPI

She is not a witch.

THEODOR

I know.

SEPPI

Then why is no one saying
anything.
No one in that square is a
witch. There are no witches.
There is only the commission
and the fear and the crowd
deciding that pointing at
someone else means the
pointing will not turn to
them.

SEPPI

Can Philip do something.

THEODOR

No. He will not. He says
stopping one ceremony does
not change the town that
holds it.

SEPPI

Does he know what happens to
her.

The teacher disappears through the church doors. The crowd
disperses.

SEPPI

I threw a stone once. At a
woman they were taking. I did
not want to. Everyone around
me was throwing stones and I
threw one so no one would
notice I did not want to.

He looks at his hands.

SEPPI (CONT'D)

I have thought about it every
day since.

THEODOR

Philip says sixty-two out of
a hundred people at any such
event do not want to be
there. They participate
because they are afraid of
the eight who do.

SEPPI

That makes it worse, not
better.

THEODOR

Yes. It does.

SEPPI

Then what do you do with it.

THEODOR

You remember that you threw
the stone. And you do not
throw the next one.

INT. ANTIQUE SHOP - WEEKS LATER - NIGHT

Philip has been gone. He returns without announcement and
takes his chair.

THEODOR

I want to understand the whole of it. Not just what happened here. All of it. Where the chain begins.

PHILIP

You want me to show you history.

EXT. OPEN FIELD - BATTLE AFTERMATH - CONTINUOUS

A field of the dead after a battle. No flag Theodor recognizes. No century he can name. The scale of it beyond anything St. Petersburg prepared him for.

Philip walks through it.

PHILIP

The statesman who started this war did not fight in it. He invented a reason. He put the reason in newspapers and in pulpits. Any man who said he was not certain was made to feel his uncertainty was cowardice. Every man with doubts was silenced by his neighbor's opinion before he could form a sentence. That is how it is done. That is how it has always been done.

THEODOR

The statesmen who do this. Do they know they are lying.

PHILIP

Every last one of them.

THEODOR

And the men who go to fight.

PHILIP

They believe what they were told. They believe it because

believing it is the only way
to live with what they are
doing. The moral sense
produces that too. The
self-deception. Without it
they could not function.

EXT. ROMAN STREET - CONTINUOUS

A Roman street at the empire's height. Slaves under guard.
A crowd watching a public execution.

PHILIP

Monarchy. Aristocracy.
Democracy. All different
arrangements for managing the
same problem. The individual
does not trust his neighbor.
He wants someone to distrust
on his behalf and calls this
civilization.

THEODOR

Are any of them better than
the others.

PHILIP

For the people at the bottom
of each, not in any way that
matters.

EXT. WORLD WAR TRENCH - CONTINUOUS

A trench. Men standing in mud to their knees. The sky
above the parapet red from something burning far off. Gas
moves across the dark ground in a low yellow cloud. Men
reaching for masks. Some too late.

PHILIP

The moral sense in its final
form. The capacity to imagine
exactly what the gas does to
the lungs used to design a
more efficient delivery
system. No other creature on

this earth could build this.
Only the animal with the
moral sense.

THEODOR

We are proud of it. Father
Peter said it makes man heir
to immortality.

PHILIP

Father Peter was a good man.
He was wrong about that.

EXT. THE GARDEN - DAWN

Simple. Green. Two figures in the distance, nameless and
still in the first light.

PHILIP

Before the moral sense. They
kill to eat. They do not know
wrong because wrong does not
exist yet. Then the apple.
Suddenly they can judge
themselves and each other.
Which means condemn. Which
means construct elaborate
reasons for doing to each
other what no wolf would do
to another wolf.

EXT. ST. PETERSBURG - HILLSIDE - WEEKS LATER

Philip and Theodor on the hill. The town below.

PHILIP

I want to show you one more
thing before you have seen
everything.

THEODOR

What.

PHILIP

How wars start. Not the wars
themselves. How they begin.

How a whole nation of people
who do not want to fight ends
up fighting.

THEODOR

Show me.

EXT. TOWN SQUARE - A DIFFERENT TOWN - CONTINUOUS

A square in a town larger than St. Petersburg. A SPEAKER
on a platform. A crowd.

The speaker's words are not audible. But the crowd's
response is. Slow at first. Uncertain. Then louder. Then
unanimous.

The few in the crowd who are not cheering look around at
their neighbors and go quiet.

PHILIP

Sixty-two of those hundred
people have no desire to
cheer. They are cheering
because they are watching
each other. Each one thinks
the others believe what the
speaker is saying. None of
them want to be the one
person standing still.

THEODOR

So they all cheer.

PHILIP

Every time. In every country.
In every century. A loud
handful makes a noise and a
quiet majority that disagrees
goes along with it because
the individual does not trust
his own judgment against the
crowd's.

THEODOR

What would happen if one
person stayed still.

PHILIP

In some centuries, nothing.
In others, everything. One
person with a steady face and
a clear voice can move a
crowd that six armies could
not move. Your race does not
understand its own power in
that direction.

PHILIP

Because it is too afraid.
Monarchies, aristocracies,
religions. All built on that
one thing. The individual's
fear of standing apart from
his neighbor.

THEODOR

And the wars.

PHILIP

There has never been a just
war. Never an honorable one
on the part of the country
that started it. The loud
handful will shout for the
war. The pulpit will object
quietly at first and then
stop objecting. The great
mass of people will say it is
unjust and dishonorable. Then
the handful will shout
louder. And one by one the
mouths will close. And then
the whole nation will take up
the cry and mob anyone who
speaks against it. And the
statesmen will invent cheap
lies and put the blame on the
nation being attacked and
every man will be glad of the
lies because they let him
sleep.

PHILIP

I can see a million years ahead. This pattern will not change in more than a handful of instances.

THEODOR

Then what is the point of any of it.

PHILIP

That is the question your race has been asking since the garden. The answer is that there is no point. There is only what you do with the link you are standing on.

THEODOR

God should not have given it to them.

PHILIP

Now you understand him.

THEODOR

That is not understanding. That is an accusation.

PHILIP

Yes. It is both.

EXT. ST. PETERSBURG - HILLSIDE - RETURNING

The same hillside. The town below.

THEODOR

What does it add up to.

PHILIP

Every act is the first link in a chain. The first act generates the second. You cannot undo the chain. You can only stand where you are and see the one link directly in front of you.

THEODOR
And you can see all of them.

PHILIP
From any point in the chain.

THEODOR
Then you knew. Before you
ever came to this town. You
knew about Lisa and Nikolaus
and Frau Brandt and
everything.

THEODOR
Then why did you come.

PHILIP
I was curious.

THEODOR
About what.

PHILIP
About you.

PHILIP (CONT'D)
I have walked through a great
many towns in a great many
centuries. Most people, when
they see what I have shown
you, either break or build a
wall around it so they do not
have to feel it. You have
done neither.

THEODOR
I have not decided what to do
with it yet.

PHILIP
I know. That is what I was
curious about.

EXT. ST. PETERSBURG - BECKY'S HOUSE - GARDEN - AFTERNOON

Theodor and Becky in the garden behind her house. She is mending something. He is not doing anything.

BECKY

Tell me about the wars.

THEODOR

Which ones.

BECKY

All of them. What he showed you.

THEODOR

Fields of the dead. Bigger than anything you can imagine from here. Then bigger than that. Gas in trenches. Weapons that burn whole cities.

BECKY

And people still make them.

BECKY

Because of the chain.

THEODOR

Because of the moral sense. He says the capacity to imagine another person's suffering is what lets you design a better weapon. You have to be able to imagine what the gas does to the lungs to figure out how to make more of it and get it there faster.

BECKY

That is a horrible way to look at it.

THEODOR

Yes. It is also accurate.

BECKY

And yet here we are. Both of us. With the moral sense. And neither of us has built a weapon today.

THEODOR

No.

BECKY

So it is not only that.

THEODOR

No. Philip says it is both. The same instrument.

BECKY

You and I are the same instrument as the men who make those weapons.

BECKY

Then the question is not whether we have the moral sense. The question is what we point it at.

THEODOR

He did not say it that way.

BECKY

I know. I am saying it this way.

THEODOR

It is better this way.

BECKY

setting down her
mending
Theodor. I want to ask you something and I want you to answer it directly.

THEODOR

All right.

BECKY

When Philip leaves. And he
will leave. What do you do
with all of this.

THEODOR

I do not know yet.

BECKY

Yes you do. You just have not
said it.

THEODOR

I write it down. All of it.
And I keep living. The same
way Frau Brandt kept standing
in the square after
everything they took from
her. You do not stop standing
just because the ground is
bad.

THEODOR

That is not hopeful.

BECKY

No. But it is true. And true
is better.

EXT. ST. PETERSBURG - RIVER PATH - EVENING

Theodor and BECKY THATCHER, 17, walking the river path.
The water calm now. Late summer light.

BECKY

You have been different since
spring.

THEODOR

I know.

BECKY

Not sad exactly. More like
someone who found something
out and is not sure what to
do with it.

THEODOR
That is accurate.

BECKY
What did he show you.

THEODOR
Wars. From the beginning to
what is still coming. The
chain connecting every act to
every other act. The moral
sense as the thing that makes
every war and every burning
possible.

BECKY
And Frau Brandt forgiving the
crowd from the stake. That
too.

THEODOR
He told me that too. Yes.

BECKY
What did you decide.

THEODOR
I have not decided yet.

BECKY
Here is what I think. If
every act connects forward
and nothing undoes the chain,
then what we do now matters
more than it did before. It
does not release us. It holds
us.

THEODOR
Philip would say that is the
moral sense constructing
purpose where there is none.

BECKY
Philip is not here. I have
the link I am standing on.

And this evening is it.
She takes his hand.

THEODOR
He told me you would be the
most honest person in this
town.

BECKY
He said that.

BECKY
I will take it.

EXT. ST. PETERSBURG - FATHER PETER'S HOUSE - WEEKS LATER

Marget has announced a party. Forty guests. The village has been suspicious about where the food comes from in that house but curiosity has overcome the suspicion and most of them are coming.

INT. FATHER PETER'S HOUSE - PARLOR - EVENING - THE PARTY

The forty guests fill the house. The food and wine are extraordinary. People who have not spoken to Marget in a year are suddenly warm and glad to be there.

Philip arrives. The room is ten degrees cooler. Every young woman in it wants to speak to him.

The Astrologer arrived without invitation. He sits at a corner table eating and watching.

He pours from a two-pint bottle into a four-quart bowl. The bowl fills to the brim. He holds up the bottle. Still full.

Father Adolf rises, shouting witchcraft. His mouth keeps moving and no sound comes out.

Philip steps into the Astrologer's body like smoke into a room. The Astrologer looks out at the crowd with Philip's patience.

ASTROLOGER

Philip behind his
eyes

Wait. Remain where you are.

He takes the bowl and pours every drop back into the bottle. The bottle receives it all and is no fuller than before.

ASTROLOGER (CONT'D)

It is nothing. Anybody can do
it. With my powers I can do
much more.

The room empties in seconds. Guests pour into the street.

Philip steps back out of the Astrologer. The Astrologer looks around the empty room, furious and confused.

Philip is gone.

INT. FATHER PETER'S HOUSE - PARLOR - AFTER

Marget. Ursula. Wilhelm. The party wrecked around them.

MARGET

to Wilhelm

Go home. This will finish
what is left of your
reputation.

WILHELM

I am staying.

MARGET

Wilhelm.

WILHELM

Marget. I am not going.

She stops arguing.

EXT. ST. PETERSBURG - MARKET SQUARE - FOLLOWING DAYS

The village talks about nothing else. What happened at Marget's house. What it means. Father Adolf says the house is cursed. The Astrologer says the same.

Theodor and Seppi walk through the square and people look at them sideways. They have always been associated with

Father Peter. Now they are associated with whatever happened at that party.

Philip finds Theodor on the hill.

PHILIP
The trial is in three days.

THEODOR
I know.

PHILIP
Wilhelm will win it.

THEODOR
How. He has nothing.

PHILIP
He has the coins. And he will see what is on them at the right moment.

THEODOR
You will help him.

PHILIP
I will allow him to think more clearly than he usually does. That is all it requires.

THEODOR
And Father Peter. Afterward. You told Marget he would be happy.

PHILIP
He will be.

THEODOR
The way Father Peter understands happy, or the way you understand it.

Philip looks at him.

PHILIP
That is a good question.

THEODOR
What is the answer.

PHILIP
The way I understand it.
Theodor stops walking.

THEODOR
Tell me what that means.

PHILIP
It means he will never suffer
again. Not one more day of
it. Not one hour.

THEODOR
And the cost of that.

PHILIP
He will not be himself. He
will be happy. Those are
different things.

THEODOR
You could find another way.

PHILIP
I said I would make him
happy. This is the only way
available to me. An
absolutely happy man is a man
whose mind no longer works
the way yours does. Sanity
and happiness cannot coexist.
No sane man can be happy, for
to him life is real and he
sees what a fearful thing it
is.

THEODOR
That is the most terrible
thing you have ever said.

PHILIP
It is the most accurate thing
I have ever said.

INT. COURTHOUSE - DAY

Every seat filled. Father Peter accused of stealing eleven hundred ducats from the Astrologer's desk.

Father Peter at the defendant's table. Thin from prison.

The Astrologer at the plaintiff's table. Prepared and composed.

Wilhelm stands for the defense.

Marget in the gallery with Ursula. The boys beside them. Philip two rows back, invisible to everyone.

ASTROLOGER

to the court

The coins were in my desk.
Father Peter was alone in my
house that afternoon. The
following morning the coins
were gone. I have seven
witnesses.

Wilhelm rises. He looks at his notes. Puts them down.
Picks up a gold coin from the evidence table and turns it
over.

WILHELM

I would ask the Clerk to read
the date stamped on the
reverse of each of these
coins.

The CLERK examines them one at a time.

CLERK

Seventeen-hundred and five.
Seventeen-hundred and five.
Seventeen-hundred and four.
Seventeen-hundred and five.

Every coin. The same.

WILHELM

The theft is alleged to have
occurred in seventeen-hundred
and two. Every coin in this
tray was minted between two
and three years after that

date. On the date they were
said to have been stolen,
these coins did not exist.

The room goes quiet.

The Astrologer says nothing.

JUDGE

The charges against Father
Peter are dismissed.

Marget on her feet. Ursula weeping. Wilhelm at his table,
surprised at himself.

Philip is gone from his row.

INT. PRISON CORRIDOR - CONTINUOUS

Philip walks to Father Peter's cell. The guards do not
notice him.

PHILIP

through the bars
Father Peter. The trial is
over. You stand forever
disgraced as a thief. The
verdict of the court.

Father Peter sits with it. He is quiet.

Then a loosening in his face. His eyes go somewhere far
away from this cell.

A smile begins. Something larger than relief. Nothing to
do with courts or the Astrologer.

FATHER PETER

softly, to
himself

Yes. Yes of course. I see it
now. I see all of it.

He stands and looks at Philip with the warmth of a man who
has been given everything.

FATHER PETER (CONT'D)

You there. Tell the Grand
Chamberlain the Emperor has
orders.

INT. PRISON - FATHER PETER'S CELL - MINUTES LATER

Marget pushes to the bars.

MARGET

Uncle. You are free. The
charges were dismissed. You
are coming home.

FATHER PETER

with great
tenderness

My dear. Why are you crying.
There is no occasion for it.

Marget stares at him.

FATHER PETER (CONT'D)

Tell me your trouble and it
shall be mended. There is
nothing the Emperor cannot
do.

MARGET

to Theodor
What has happened to him.

THEODOR

Philip told him he was
convicted. The shock of it.
Then the relief came too
fast.

MARGET

Is this forever.

Father Peter pats Marget's hand through the bars and
smiles at the ceiling, seeing something beautiful there.

PHILIP

appearing beside
Theodor

Sanity and happiness are an
impossible combination. No
sane man can be happy. I have
taken from him the thing your
race calls a mind and
replaced his life with a
silver-gilt fiction. He is

the happiest man in this
empire.

THEODOR
You could not have done it
another way.

PHILIP
I said I would make him
happy. He is happy. I kept my
word.

MARGET
keeping her hand
in her uncle's,
to Theodor
I know this was not your
doing.

THEODOR
Marget.

MARGET
I know. I am not angry at
you.
Father Peter beams at the ceiling.

EXT. ST. PETERSBURG - OUTSIDE PRISON - AFTER

Wilhelm walks Marget home. The street is quiet. The
verdict has spread through the village but most people
have gone inside.

MARGET
I do not know what to do with
him.

WILHELM
He is safe. He is fed. He is
happy.

MARGET
He thinks he is the Emperor.

WILHELM
I know.

MARGET
He will think that forever.

WILHELM
I know.

MARGET
I wanted him back. I wanted
the trial over and him home
and things the way they were.

WILHELM
I know.

MARGET
This is not that.

WILHELM
No. But he is home. And he is
not suffering. And I am here.

MARGET
You stayed through all of it.

MARGET
Everyone else left.

MARGET
Why.

WILHELM
Because I knew him. Because I
know you.
She does not answer. But she does not move away from him
either.

INT. ANTIQUE SHOP - NIGHT

Theodor and Philip.

THEODOR
He will be like that forever.

PHILIP
Yes. He will give away
kingdoms until he dies and he

will die the happiest man who
ever lived in this town.

THEODOR

And you are satisfied with
that.

PHILIP

I am not satisfied or
dissatisfied. I kept my word.

THEODOR

Seppi said seeing everything
and feeling none of it sounds
lonely.

PHILIP

You have said that before.

THEODOR

I am saying it again.

PHILIP

I have been thinking about it
since Seppi said it.

THEODOR

And.

PHILIP

And I think he may be right.

PHILIP (CONT'D)

I have walked through a great
many towns. I have seen
everything that happens in
each one. I keep coming back
to this one.

THEODOR

Why.

PHILIP

I do not know. That is the
honest answer. I came back
curious about you. I have
stayed for reasons I cannot

fully account for. That is
not something I have
experienced before.

THEODOR
Maybe that is what it feels
like. From outside.
Loneliness.

PHILIP
Maybe.

THEODOR
Are you leaving.

PHILIP
Not yet.

INT. ANTIQUE SHOP - LATE NIGHT

Philip in his chair. Theodor across the table.

THEODOR
How long have you been doing
this.

PHILIP
A long time. Your units of
time do not translate well to
my experience of it. But by
any measure, a very long
time.

THEODOR
And before that.

PHILIP
Before I could walk through
towns on my own I was a child
in the nursery of angels.
Which is a thing that has no
equivalent in your
experience. I was young for
eight thousand of your years.

THEODOR

What was that like.

PHILIP

I do not know how to describe it in terms you have access to. There was no suffering in it. There was no loneliness either, at the time.

THEODOR

At the time.

PHILIP

Yes. At the time.

THEODOR

And now.

PHILIP

Now I sit in an antique shop in a small town in seventeen-hundred and two and a sixteen-year-old boy asks me questions I have not been asked before.

THEODOR

That is not an answer.

PHILIP (CONT'D)

Your father sells things that belonged to people who are dead. Every object here meant something to someone who no longer exists. I find that the most interesting thing about this shop. Not the objects. The fact that meaning outlasts the person who made it.

THEODOR

Is that what we are to you. Objects that outlast the people who made them.

PHILIP

No. You are something I do not have a category for. That is unusual.

THEODOR

Unusual for an angel.

PHILIP

Unusual for anything I have encountered in several thousand years of encountering things.

THEODOR

Seppi was right.

PHILIP

About the loneliness.

PHILIP

I am beginning to think so.

EXT. ST. PETERSBURG - RIVER PATH - MORNING

Theodor and Becky walking. Early autumn now. The leaves beginning to change.

BECKY

Father Peter came to the square yesterday.

THEODOR

I heard.

BECKY

He gave three women titles of nobility. They were very pleased.

THEODOR

He gave Seppi a duchy last week.

BECKY

How is Seppi.

THEODOR
His mother is better. Like
Philip said she would be.

BECKY
He is reliable about those
things.

BECKY
Is he reliable about
everything.

THEODOR
About facts, yes. About what
they mean, that is a
different question.

BECKY
What do you mean.

THEODOR
He can tell you exactly what
will happen. He cannot tell
you what it is worth. He can
see the chain but he cannot
feel it. Those are different
kinds of knowing.

BECKY
And you can feel it but not
see it.

BECKY
Then together you might have
the whole picture.

BECKY (CONT'D)
That was a joke.

THEODOR
I know. But it is also true.

INT. ANTIQUE SHOP - LATE NIGHT

Theodor working at the table. Writing in his notebook. He
has started keeping a record of everything Philip has

said. Not in Philip's words exactly but in his own. What it means to him, what he understands from it.

Philip comes in.

PHILIP

You are writing about our conversations.

PHILIP

Why.

THEODOR

Because I will be old one day and I will not remember exactly. And I think the exactness matters.

PHILIP

What have you written.

THEODOR

The moral sense. The chain. The castle and the five hundred people. Lisa. Nikolaus. Frau Brandt. Father Peter. The battles and the garden. All of it.

PHILIP

And what have you concluded.

THEODOR

I have not concluded anything. I am still inside it.

PHILIP

That is the correct answer.

THEODOR

It does not feel like the correct answer. It feels like failure.

PHILIP

Every person I have shown
these things to has either
reached a conclusion
immediately or never
recovered from it. You are
doing neither. That is not
failure.

THEODOR
What is it.

PHILIP
I do not have a word for it.

INT. ANTIQUE SHOP - NIGHT

Philip arrives. He sits in his chair.

THEODOR
You are leaving.

PHILIP
How do you know.

THEODOR
You sat down and did not say
anything. You always say
something.

PHILIP
Yes. I am leaving.

THEODOR
When.

PHILIP
Tonight.

THEODOR
Why tonight.

PHILIP
Because if I stay longer I
will keep finding reasons to
stay longer. That is not
something I am equipped to

manage.

THEODOR

Where are you going.

PHILIP

There are other corners of the universe that require attention. There are other things I have been putting off.

THEODOR

Because of this town.

PHILIP

Because of this town.

THEODOR

Will you come back.

PHILIP

No.

THEODOR

I will miss you.

PHILIP

I know.

THEODOR

Will you miss me.

PHILIP

I do not know how to miss things. But I think I will notice your absence in a way I have not noticed anything's absence before. That may be the closest I can come to it.

THEODOR

That is enough.

PHILIP

Yes. I think it is.

EXT. ST. PETERSBURG - OUTSKIRTS - NIGHT

They go through the dark streets and out past the last house into the open field.

Philip stops. He takes a seed from his coat.

THEODOR

What is that.

PHILIP

A seed.

THEODOR

What will you raise from it.

PHILIP

Whatever you like.

THEODOR

An apple tree.

PHILIP

That is sufficient.

He presses it into the earth.

PHILIP (CONT'D)

Rise.

A thread of green. Then faster. The stem thickens, the trunk widens, branches reach outward. An apple tree growing at a speed no natural process allows.

In two minutes it is an enormous apple tree. The branches reach forty feet in every direction and hang heavy with apples. Every apple perfect. Every branch full.

The apples do not fall. The tree does not thin. It holds everything it has made.

THEODOR

This is not how trees work.

PHILIP

No.

He reaches up and takes an apple from a low branch and hands it to Theodor. They sit under it in the grass.

EXT. UNDER THE TREE - CONTINUOUS

The field around them. The stars overhead through the branches.

Theodor eats the apple. It is the best apple he has ever eaten.

PHILIP

Have you ever suspected it.
In all the nights reading.
All the mornings at that
step.

THEODOR

Suspected what.

PHILIP

That none of this is real.

THEODOR

What do you mean, none of
this.

PHILIP

God. Man. The world. The sun,
the moon, the wilderness of
stars. A dream. All a dream.
They have no existence.
Nothing exists save empty
space.

He reaches up and takes an apple from the branch above
him.

PHILIP (CONT'D)

And you.

THEODOR

I.

PHILIP

You have no body, no blood,
no bones. You are but a
thought. I myself have no
existence. I am but a dream,
a creature of your
imagination.

He is already less present. The way a flame is less present when the air around it changes.

PHILIP (CONT'D)

Strange that you should not have suspected it years ago. Strange because it is so frankly and hysterically insane, like all dreams. A God who could make good children as easily as bad yet preferred to make bad ones. Who made them prize their bitter life yet stingily cut it short. Who mouths justice and invented hell. Who mouths mercy and invented hell. Who mouths Golden Rules and invented hell.

He sets it down in the grass.

PHILIP (CONT'D)

You perceive that these things are impossible except in a dream. They are the silly creations of an imagination not conscious of its own freaks. They are a dream and you are the maker of it.

PHILIP (CONT'D)

There is no God, no universe, no human race, no earthly life, no heaven, no hell. It is all a dream. A grotesque and foolish dream. Nothing exists but you. And you are but a thought. A vagrant thought, wandering forlorn among the empty eternities.

He turns to Theodor.

PHILIP (CONT'D)

I have revealed you to yourself and set you free.

Dream other dreams, and
better.

He dissolves. The shape of him remains visible for a moment longer than physics allows, colors moving through it the way colors move through a soap bubble just before it vanishes. Then nothing. The air where he stood is simply air.

Theodor sits under the tree alone.

The apples are still there. Every branch still full. The tree holds everything it made.

He reaches up and takes an apple. Holds it in both hands.

He looks up through the branches at the sky and through the sky at everything beyond it, all the way to the edge of whatever the dream is made of.

The stars wheel.

Then, dawn comes up over the field.

EXT. ST. PETERSBURG - RIVER PATH - YEARS LATER

Theodor and Becky walking the river path, older now. Two children run ahead of them toward the water. Theodor calls out to them to stay back from the edge.

He says it exactly the way Nikolaus used to say it to Lisa.

He stops walking for a moment. Becky takes his arm.

He never sees Philip again.

He lives a long life. He writes everything down. He dies in the same chair where he first wrote about that summer, in the back room of his father's shop, the notebook open on the table in front of him.

THE VOID

Darkness. Not the darkness of a room or a night. The darkness of nothing.

In it, a figure.

PHILIP. Exactly as he was. Long pale hair. The face that belongs to no age. Alone in a darkness that has no edges and no end.

And in that darkness of the cosmos, forever a prisoner of the universe, Satan wept.

FADE TO BLACK.

THE MYSTERIOUS STRANGER

**Based on No. 44, The Mysterious Stranger and The Chronicle
of Young Satan by Mark Twain**